

Lotus Temple

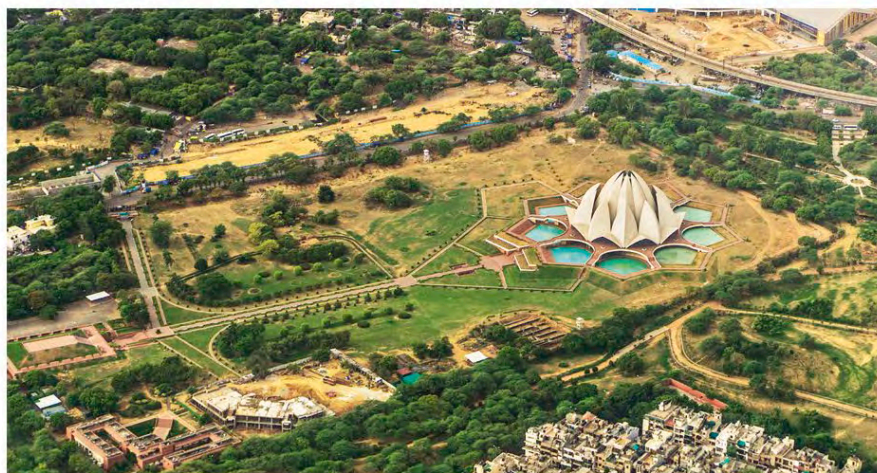
A spectacular Bahá'í House of Worship in Delhi that is designed to imitate the petals of a sacred flower



The basic tenet of the Bahá'í faith is the unity of all religions. The Lotus Temple, a *mashriqu'l-adhkár* ("house of worship") built in New Delhi in 1986, gives visual expression to this belief by adopting the form of a lotus, an aquatic flower recognized as a symbol of purity and immortality in Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, and Islam.

A flower about to bloom

Architect Fariborz Sahba, an Iranian living in North America, created an innovative building enclosed by 27 petals. Each petal is clad in dazzling marble brought from Mount Pentelicus in Greece. Reflecting the Bahá'í belief in the sacred properties of the number nine, the petals are arranged to create a building with nine sides and nine entrances. There are nine pools around the temple, which make the half-open lotus blossom appear as if it is floating on water. The domed inner space of the temple can hold 2,500 people. The building is open to people of all religious faiths. By the 21st century, the Lotus Temple has come to rival the Taj Mahal (see pp.290–291) as north India's most popular attraction.



△ LANDSCAPED SURROUNDINGS

The temple is built on a raised platform amid a wide expanse of landscaped gardens that extend over an area of 1.2 million square ft (110,000 square m).

